

Activist Marketing Strategy: Black + Forth

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01

Introduction

Who is Black + Forth?

Meet Angel Gregorio

“D.C. is considered one of the most gentrified cities in the nation, and it’s evident,” - Angel Gregorio

- Howard University Alumni
- Born and raised in Washington, DC
- Opened her first Spice Shop in Tacoma (DC Neighborhood)
- At age 38, she purchased a 7,500-square-foot lot in Northeast Washington’s Langdon Park neighborhood



Meet: Black+Forth

Location:

2201 Channing St NE, Washington, DC 20018

The Black and Forth Farmers Market: bi-weekly outdoor marketplace that hosts all Black vendors, including Mid-Atlantic region farmers and food artisans, at the Black and Forth strip mall in Washington, DC.

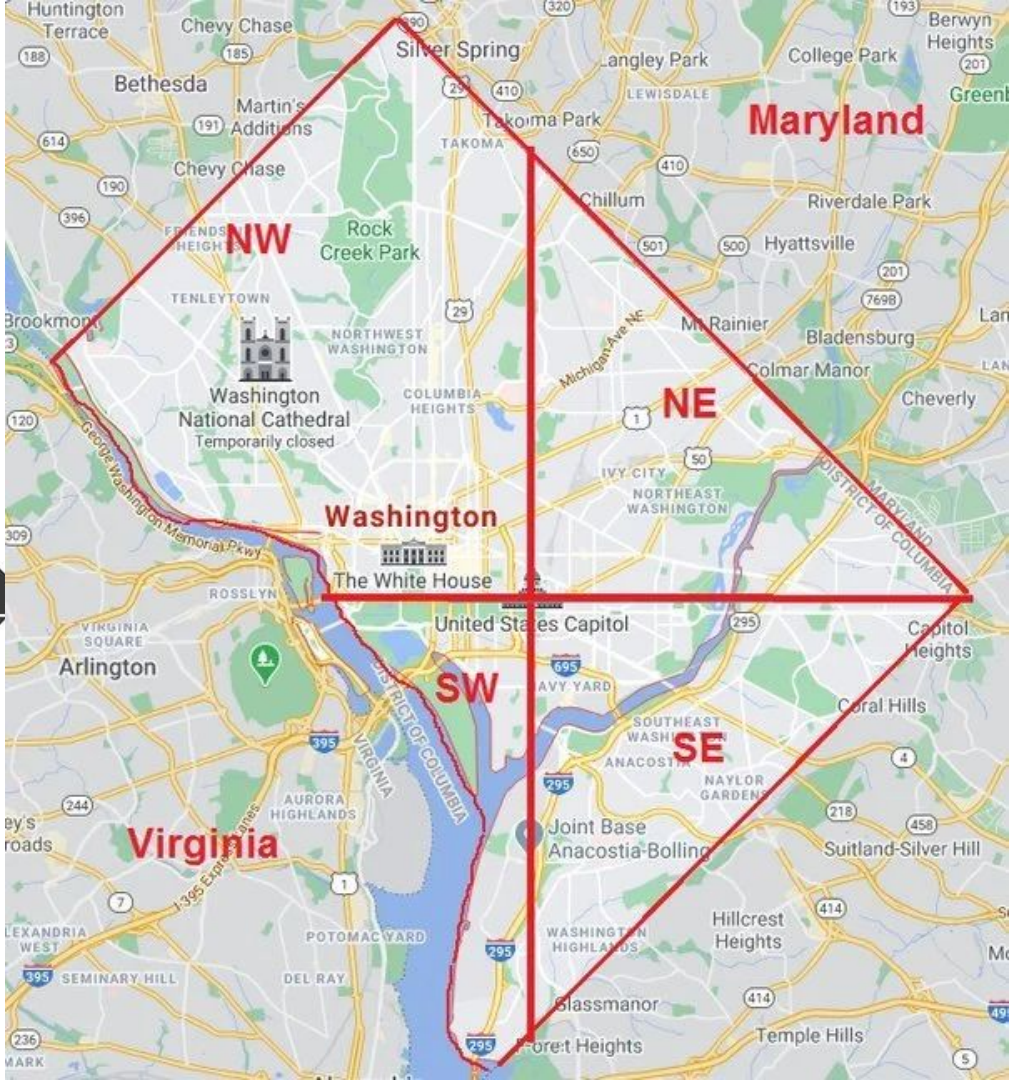
Featuring:

- Skin Elite DMV
- Egypt Ami Wellness
- She Nailed It
- BeautiMarc
- The Spice Suite

Hosts Free business classes
Offer scholarships



BLACK +FORTH



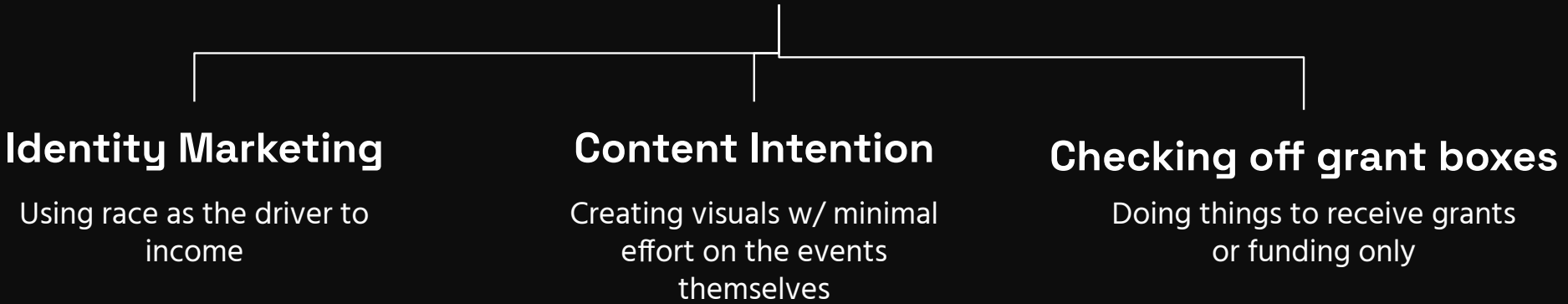
02

Activism vs. Performance

Which is which?

Performance

Performative Activism



Identity Marketing

Using race as the driver to
income

Content Intention

Creating visuals w/ minimal
effort on the events
themselves

Checking off grant boxes

Doing things to receive grants
or funding only

Activism

Authentic Activism

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graph TD; AA[Authentic Activism] --- R[Redirection]; AA --- MO[Measurable Outcomes]; AA --- NROI[Not ROI Focused];
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Redirection

Telling customers about other businesses or organizations that can help them

Measurable Outcomes

Striving to see and measuring success

Not ROI Focused

Not always aiming for profit but to have community profit.

03

Central Question

Can a brand really be an activist if its ultimate goal is to sell a product or service?

Yes, but with some conditions.

**Authenticity + Consistency + Intentionality + Core Values =
True Brand Activism**

04

Brand Audit

What are they doing wrong? What are they doing right?

Strengths

The Farmers Market

Brings community together, highlights local black-owned businesses & farmers, huge economic surplus for businesses, and free entry for vendors.



Cultural specificity and awareness

Ties in the DC identity, "mumbo sauce", "Carry out", GoGo music all in Celebration of culture and the people.

Weaknesses

The Activism is not legible to new and current Washingtonians

Is Angel running a Black-owned business that does some activist things, or is she building an activist institution that happens to sell goods and services.



Huge disconnect between The Spice Suite and Black + Forth

Appears that Black + Forth is an afterthought to The Spice Suite.

Consumers know more about the spices than the advocacy.

05

New Brand Strategy

Introducing the 3 pillars for success!

Pillar One: Black and Forth Mission Integration



What they do now

They offer classes for free surrounding business ownership, personal development and financial literacy.

What I'm Changing

Reframe The Spice Suite as the revenue engine that funds Black and Forth.

The website needs a unified story. Making the mission more visible.



BLACK
+ FORTH

If “each one, teach one” was a business model.

Pillar Two: Leaving the Location & Building the Brand!

What they do now

Everything happens on their property, they do not travel. Angel is the only known entity of Black + Forth.

What I'm Changing

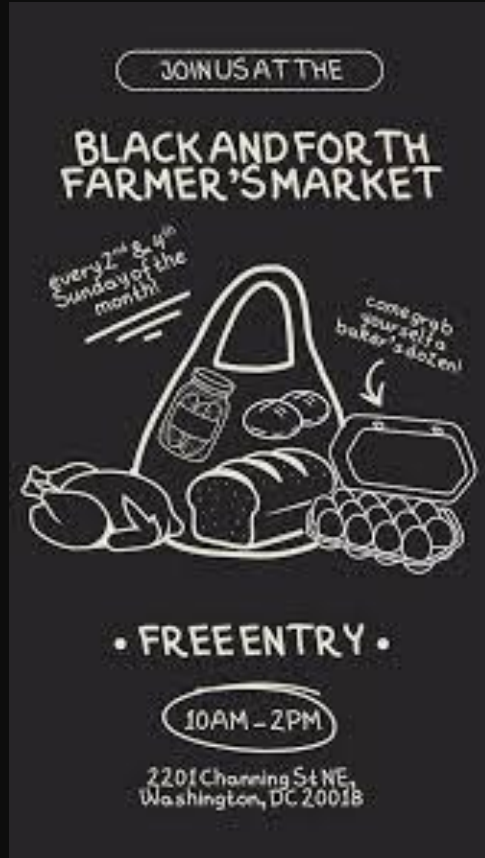
Developing pop-ups throughout DC, visiting high schools, & offering classes at accessible locations.

Moving the focus away from Angel (There are more picture of her than any of the businesses)

Highlighting the other businesses and focusing on the brand rather than a person's brand.



Pillar Three: Policy & Advocacy Partnerships



What they do now

"Support Black - Owned Business"

Are they supporting business owners or the community?

What I'm Changing

Giving this a meaning. Picking a specific policy issue to focus on each year.

Hiring students through the Marion Barry Summer Youth Employment Program.

Measurement & Risks

How will we measure success? What are the Risks?

Risks of Implementation

Commercialization of the mission

Making the mission more visible increases the stakes to being held accountable!

Angel burnout

Considering Angel seems to be the only figure running this organization it may be overwhelming to incorporate these pillars.

Audience mismatch

Considering DC is becoming predominantly white, people may not want their purchases to become political.

Measurement of Impact

Economic redistribution

Dollars paid out to pop-up vendors annually,
number of Black-owned businesses
platformed, vendor success stories
(businesses that grew from Spice Suite
pop-ups into their own storefronts).

Community impact

How many attendees for the classes, how
much money in scholarships given, staff
success stories, and community
improvement.

Civic Engagement

Voting education, number of new registered
voters, number of new non profits at the
farmers markets.

Thank You !
Any Questions?